

YouTube.com

History & Founding

- **Founded:** Feb 14, 2005 by former PayPal employees Steve Chen, Chad Hurley, and Jawed Karim ¹ ² . The first video ("Me at the zoo" by Jawed Karim) was posted on April 23, 2005 and has been viewed over 372 million times ³ .
- **Acquisition:** Google bought YouTube in Nov 2006 for US\$1.65 billion ¹ ⁴ , and it now operates as a Google subsidiary.

Key Features & Services

- **Video sharing & social:** Users can upload videos, watch and rate (like/dislike) them, comment, share links, organize playlists, and subscribe to channels ⁵ .
- **Live streaming:** Supports real-time broadcasts (introduced Apr 2011 ⁶). Common uses include gaming streams, news events, and live concerts.
- **Short-form videos (Shorts):** Vertical clips up to ~60 seconds (TikTok-style) launched in Sept 2020 ⁷ .
- **Recommendations:** A personalized algorithm suggests videos based on user history. Since 2012 it emphasizes *watch time* (total viewing duration) to prioritize engaging content ⁸ .
- **Premium & subscriptions:** Paid tiers include YouTube Premium (ad-free viewing and music, launched 2018) and YouTube TV (live TV service). YouTube Premium had 125 million+ subscribers by 2025 ⁹ .
- **Creator tools & commerce:** YouTube provides features like automatic captions, analytics (YouTube Studio), and mobile/TV apps. Creators can sell merchandise via a "Merch Shelf" and tag products with YouTube Shopping ¹⁰ .

Usage & Popularity

- **User base:** Over 2.5 billion people use YouTube each month ¹¹ (roughly 30–45% of global internet users ¹²). It is one of the most-visited sites worldwide (Alexa ranks it #2 after Google) ¹³ .
- **Global reach:** Available in 100+ countries and 80+ languages. Largest user markets are India ($\approx$ 509 million) and the USA ($\approx$ 248 million) ¹² . The audience spans all age groups.
- **Engagement:** About 1 billion hours of video are watched on YouTube every day ¹³ . In 2019, over 500 hours of content were uploaded each minute ¹³ .
- **Popular content:** Music and entertainment videos dominate viewing figures. For example, PSY's "Gangnam Style" was the first video to reach 1 billion views (Dec 2012) ¹⁴ . Other top genres include gaming, educational/how-to content, vlogs, and movie/TV clips.

Business Model & Creator Earnings

- **Advertising:** YouTube is free for users; revenue mainly comes from advertising (video ads, banners, and Shorts ads). In 2024, YouTube earned roughly US\$36 billion from ads ⁹ . Creators in the YouTube Partner Program receive a share of this ad revenue (about 55% of the income from ads on their videos).

- **Premium & subscriptions:** Creators earn a portion of subscription revenue. A share of YouTube Premium (and YouTube Music) subscription fees goes to creators when members watch their content ¹⁰ (125 million Premium subscribers as of 2025 ⁹).
- **Channel memberships:** Eligible channels can offer paid monthly memberships. Fans pay monthly for perks (e.g. loyalty badges, custom emojis, special live chats) ¹⁵. Membership fees are shared with the channel.
- **Fan funding:** Viewers can tip creators. During live streams, Super Chat and Super Stickers let fans pay to highlight messages ¹⁵. For regular videos, “Super Thanks” allows one-time tips via animated comments ¹⁵.
- **Merchandise & shopping:** Creators can sell official merchandise through the built-in “Merch Shelf” under their videos ¹⁰. They can also use YouTube Shopping to tag and link products in videos, earning affiliate commissions ¹⁰.

Sources: Founding and acquisition ¹ ² ⁴ ; features ⁵ ⁷ ⁶ ⁸ ¹⁰ ¹⁵ ; usage stats ¹¹ ¹² ⁹ ¹³ ¹⁴ ; business and monetization ⁹ ¹⁰ ¹⁵.

¹ ⁵ ⁶ ⁷ ⁸ ¹³ ¹⁴ History of YouTube - Wikipedia

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/History_of_YouTube

² ⁴ YouTube | History, Founders, & Facts | Britannica

<https://www.britannica.com/topic/YouTube>

³ ¹² YouTube Stats: How Many People Use YouTube in 2024?

<https://backlinko.com/youtube-users>

⁹ How Many People Use YouTube? (2025 Active Users Stats)

<https://www.demandsage.com/youtube-stats/>

¹⁰ ¹⁵ How to earn money on YouTube - YouTube Help

<https://support.google.com/youtube/answer/72857?hl=en>

¹¹ YouTube Users, Stats, Data, Trends, and More — DataReportal – Global Digital Insights

<https://datareportal.com/essential-youtube-stats>